CINEMA

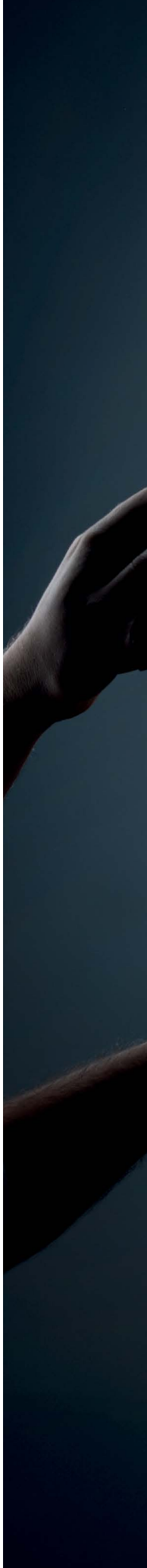
60 YEARS OF AAMIR KHAN

ROAD TO EXCELLENCE

AAMIR KHAN

Actor, Producer

What better time than on the eve of age 60 to look back at a glorious, nearly four-decade-long stint in Bollywood? Superstar Aamir Khan did exactly that, and more, at the India Today Conclave. With several Rs 100, 200 and 300 crore films, and one—*Dangal*—that breached the Rs 2,000-crore mark, Aamir's has been a long, eventful journey since he burst on to the silver screen as the loveable Raj in *Qayamat Se Qayamat Tak* in 1988 at age 23. That boyish charm continued in many a film—*Dil, Jo Jeeta Wohi Sikandar, Andaz Apna Apna, Rangeela, Raja Hindustani, Dil Chahta Hai*.... Along the road, however, Aamir also took a serious turn, not just acting in meaningful roles, but also making socially relevant cinema (*Lagaan, Lal Singh Chadha, Dangal, Taare Zameen Par, Secret Superstar, Laapataa Ladies*). He may not have chased success, but seems surprised that he found so much of it. But where others would congratulate themselves, Aamir is self-deprecating, admitting how he still battles nerves before a film's release. There were some light-hearted reminiscences too, like how he'd be the only actor to reach set on time during the shoot of *Andaz Apna Apna* and how Javed Akhtar warned him against getting Amitabh Bachchan to be the narrator in *Lagaan* given the number of flops he had voiced. Through it all, the now sexagenarian did not forget to count his blessings—namely, the two women he was married to—Reena, and Kiran Rao. "We are divorced, but that doesn't mean we don't respect and love each other," he said. As for his children, he said, all he ever wanted was for them "to be happy", "explore and be curious about things" than be toppers in class. Papa was right. "*Bada naam karega*", he had said all that many years ago. Aamir sure has, and how! ■



KEY TAKEAWAYS

Aamir's risk-taking comes at a heavy price—he can't sleep before a film's release. From producing and starring in the 3-hour, 42-minute period sports drama *Lagaan* to directing *Taare Zameen Par*, which centred on a kid battling dyslexia, Aamir always takes a leap of faith with scripts

Authenticity matters to him, which is why he felt ex-wife Kiran Rao was the right director for *Laapataa Ladies*. "I didn't want a director who would overdo it," he said. "I know her sensitivity, her creative instinct... I wanted someone who was honest in their narrative"

Excellence, not success has been the driving force in Aamir's storied career, which began with *Qayamat Se Qayamat Tak* in 1988. It's also why Rajkumar Hirani wanted Aamir, then 40-something, to play an 18-year-old in *3 Idiots*

To watch the full session, visit **https://bitly.cx/95sV**